

*Enjoy
the sea!*

WHY
BEING
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FOR
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MIND

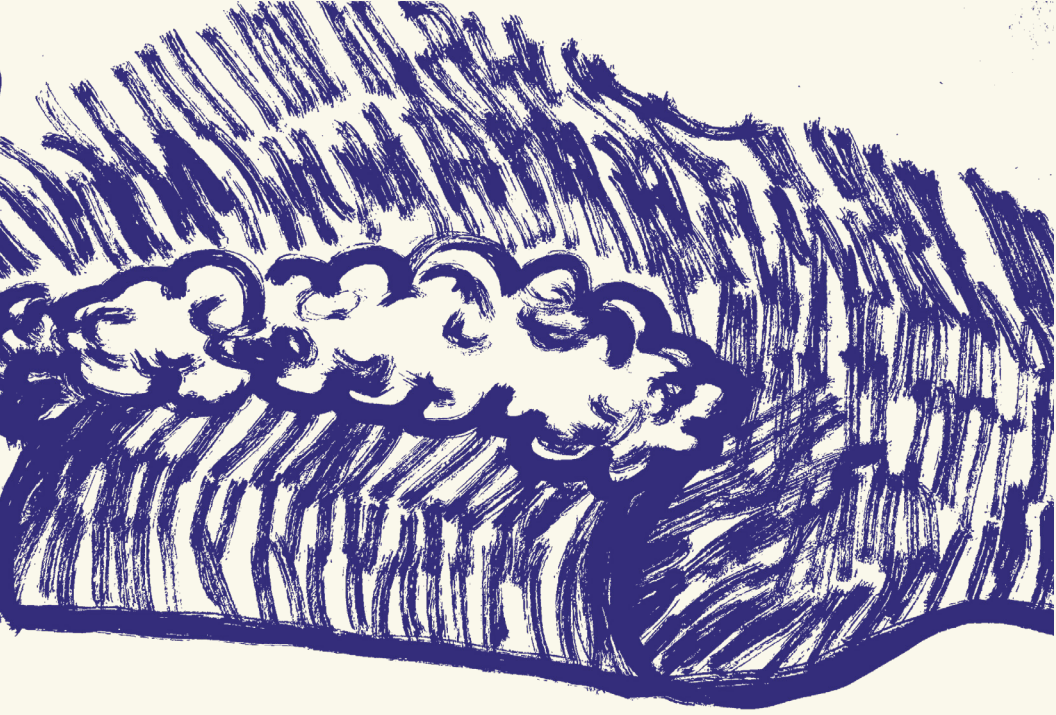
WHY BEING BY THE SEA IS GOOD FOR YOUR MIND

In this article we dig into why being beside the seaside is so beneficial to our mental health. To find out more, we spoke with some local experts including Joe Sabien, CEO of Sea Sanctuary, Lizzie Larbalestier, a Blue Health Coach and Joe Taylor, Wave Project Founder and CEO.

THE RISE OF BLUE HEALTH

Blue Health is an increasingly well researched topic. Around the world experts are looking into why blue spaces, such as the sea, can improve our physical and mental wellbeing. Many believe the sea has a therapeutic quality, finding it exciting and magical. And scientists are now proving this right being by the water rejuvenates the body and mind reducing stress and anxiety, says Joe S. Take for example, this hefty bit of research. Using survey data from nearly 26,000

respondents, researchers conducted one of the most detailed investigations into the wellbeing effects on being by the sea. And the results were incredible. Having taken other related factors into account, the research found that living in large towns and cities near England's coastline is linked with better mental health for those in the lower earning households. Another study, this time involving 20,000 smartphone users recording their wellbeing at various intervals, found marine and coastal spots were the happiest locations, faring six points higher than an urban environment. The researchers rated it as the difference between attending an exhibition and doing housework. In an interview with The Guardian, Dr Mathew White, an environmental psychologist, said there are three key factors which link coastal living and wellbeing. Firstly, in general, coastal environments are often higher quality with more sunlight and less polluted air. Secondly, people who live by the water are often more active. But the third point is particularly interesting, he says water has a psychologically restorative effect, with time by the water consistently linked with positive mood and reduced negative mood and stress. The mental health benefits of being by the sea.



The world feels like a strange place for many of us right now, but we are lucky here in Cornwall to be surrounded by the mental health boost ing powers of the sea. Simply staring out to sea listening to the waves, paddling our toes, scouring the shoreline for shells comes with a whole host of benefits. So, if you have got the opportunity, why not try a me ander along the seafloor and see how you feel afterwards.

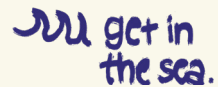
HOW TO ENJOY BEING BY THE SEA



Get out there, just a glimpse of the sea or getting a few grains of sand on your toes can change your entire outlook for the day.



Take a coastal walk and observe how the light, shapes, and color of the landscape shift, reminding us of the transitional nature of all things. Take a walk to your local beach and let your senses take in it all. Learn how the waves break, take notice of the wind.



Perhaps take up cold water swimming. If it is a good day go for a dip or a surf get in there. The feeling of accomplishment that you have truly embraced nature will stay with you all day. Any water will do. Too far from the beach itself. The watery nature of our peninsula offers rivers and estuariesteaming with wildlife and activities such as photography enable us to exercise our creativity.



Do a spot of rock pooling, collect shells, and watch the wildlife, enjoy what you observe.



If you are unable to physically get to the coast, then immerse yourself in culture, read magazines and watch TV shows about our local marine life perhaps, or listen to music inspired by the ocean can help connect you connect virtually with the coastal qualities.



Simply go and be still. This last point, often overlooked, allows us time to ourselves, to be in the moment and process what is going on for us. It isn't selfish or superfluous to our needs it's the essence of being alive and of appreciating this rich and varied world in which we live.



MEDITATIVE STATE

BIG PICTURE THINKING

IMPROVED SLEEP

GRATITUDE IMMEDIATE MINDFULNESS

MEDITATIVE STATE

Many of us intuitively feel more relaxed and at peace by the sea, but why exactly is that. Simply staring out to sea can change our brain wave frequency, luring us into a mild meditative state. The color blue is associated with feelings of calm and peace and listening to the ebb and flow of waves and the swell of the sea naturally soothes and relaxes the brain. The fresh salty sea air is full of negative ions, believed to help alleviate depression and the increased levels of Vitamin D, the sunshine vitamin, which soaks into our skin makes us feel good.

BIG PICTURE THINKING

Being by the sea also forces us to change our pace of living which can alter how we think and process information. We can slow down, stepping away from the frenetic digital world and allowing us to simply take time to be fully present in the moment. Our breathing shifts as we watch waves and wildlife and our attention is drawn from within ourselves to the outside world giving our minds the space to reset and, importantly, offering our nervous system the chance to rebalance as we connect with nature. Time in blue spaces enables us to unconsciously, and consciously, recognise the interconnection between all aspects of life within our ecosystem promoting empathy and dissolving any sense of isolation.



GRATITUDE

It is easy to slip into a negative mindset, especially given the constant challenges we are all facing at the moment. But staring out to sea, most of us cant help but feel even a momentary glimpse of gratitude, which is a powerful step towards well being. With so much going on in the world right now a trip to our beautiful coastline is a great way to reflect and remember all the positives and beauty we have around us. We must all take time indeed find this time wherever possible as without it, we can become immersed in the negative this is absolutely something to avoid. Remember too we can always find a reactionary gap we can all make space to consider the information that presents itself to us and respond accordingly through choice. We can, actively remember that wellbeing is blue, wet and around the corner.

IMMEDIATE MINDFULNESS

If you have even taken a dip in the sea, or even had a paddle, you will recognise that feeling of complete immersion in the activity. By getting into the sea you are no longer observing nature, you are in it and fully conscious of the feel, the sound, the power, and taste of the ocean. It is a powerful way of putting things into perspective. In the sea there isnt a lot of headspace left to also worry about land and life problems because the ocean demands your full presence the moment you step into it.

IMPROVED SLEEP

It is not an uncommon phenomenon to sleep well after a cobweb shifting walk by the sea, but now there is actual research to back it up. A study found that people sleep on average for 47 minutes longer after a good walk along the coast. And the sea in particular is thought to play a crucial role, as those who went on a similar length inland walk bagged only 12 minutes of extra precious snooze time. And we all know the power of a good nights sleep. Connect with your emotions. Being in the sea is being at one with the sea the space, the sensory awareness, the refreshing sensation, the motion, the smell and the challenge.

Be it swimming, surfing, sailing or SUPing, your time in the water gives you the time and opportunity to explore often self imposed limitations, allowing you to be present in that moment. And that allows people to connect with their emotions in a powerful way. That is a particularly useful side effect for people who arent into traditional methods of connection with their own emotions, such as journaling or discussing their mental health with a friend. Here at Sea Sanctuary, we believe the sea works for us in a way that is beyond language for those who struggle to articulate their emotions, the sea is something that makes people feel and connect with their emotions. There is something about the silence, the serenity and peace that can only be found in or near the sea.